

A ceremony with room to breathe

A practical planning toolkit for destination weddings in Mexico, Jamaica and Punta Cana.

Start with your people, your space and your officiant. The online builder creates a personalised text file; this PDF is your reusable companion.

Illustrative timeline: 100 guests, 4 PM ceremony, 90-minute ceremony block. All times are local to the venue. Your pandit and families determine the rituals and actual duration.

2:00 PM	Setup readiness check Check contracted access, weather backup and setup readiness.
3:00 PM	Sound check & officiant briefing Test microphones; confirm names, cues, rings and ritual materials.
3:30 PM	Guest arrival & seating Staff the welcome point; offer water and accessible seating.
3:30 PM	Baraat / family welcome - if included If included: confirm the route, length and sound permission.
4:00 PM	Ceremony begins Start the ceremony block agreed with your officiant and families.
5:30 PM	Ceremony closes Announce the next location and where guests can find assistance.
5:45 PM	Family photographs & guest transition Assign a family-photo coordinator and a guest-support lead.
6:00 PM	Hospitality / next event Confirm catering, next-space access, overtime and strike.

Before sharing the final schedule

Confirm access and strike windows, the music cutoff, the weather decision deadline and the exact backup space in writing. These suggested checkpoints do not grant venue access or confirm capacity.

Build or revise your personalised version: www.ceremonyverse.com/planning-tools/ceremony-timeline/

Your modern 12-minute ceremony

An original script with personal prompts. The suggested blocks total 12 minutes, including music, transitions and pauses. Rehearse aloud; actual timing will vary.

This is a symbolic celebration. It does not establish authority to perform a legal marriage and does not replace a Hindu ceremony. Confirm any legal ceremony requirements with the relevant local authority.

Processional / 1 min

Play the chosen entrance music. Wait until everyone is settled before speaking.

Welcome / 1.5 min

Welcome, everyone. Today we make room for a promise: to choose each other, with care, through the ordinary days as well as the extraordinary ones. [Name] and [Name], the people gathered here bring different stories, traditions, and journeys. What connects us is our love for you. Thank you to those who travelled, to those joining from afar, and to the people whose presence we carry in our hearts. Take a breath. Look at each other. There is nowhere else you need to be in this moment. [Pause; invite guests to be seated. Allow time for any agreed acknowledgement.]

Your story / 2 min

[Officiant: prepare about 180-220 words, approved by the couple. Tell one specific story about their everyday kindness, one quality each admires in the other, and what they hope to build together. Leave private details and surprise jokes out. Finish:] A shared life is made in these small acts of attention. Today you promise to keep noticing, keep listening, and keep making room for one another. [Pause.]

Reading or reflection / 1 min

[Invite a loved one to read an original, public-domain, or permission-cleared passage of about 90-110 words, or keep a quiet reflection. Rehearse the walk to the microphone as part of this minute.]

Personal story notes: _____

Promises, rings and celebration

Replace every [Name] and bracketed prompt before the rehearsal. Bracketed directions guide the officiant; they are not spoken aloud.

Personal vows / 3 min

The promises you make belong to you. [Name], please share yours. [Allow about 75 seconds.] [Name], please share yours. [Allow about 75 seconds. Keep 30 seconds for transitions and emotion. Each partner can begin: I love the way you... I promise to... When life becomes difficult, I will... The life I hope we create together is...]

Ring exchange / 1.5 min

[If exchanging rings, invite the ring holder forward.] Let these rings remind you of the promises you have made, and of the care those promises will ask of you. [Each partner repeats slowly:] I give you this ring as a reminder of my love. I choose to stand beside you, to listen with patience, and to build our life with honesty and kindness. [Allow time to place each ring. If there are no rings, use this time for a mutually chosen gesture or shorten the ceremony.]

Closing / 1 min

Your promises have been spoken, and your community has heard them. May you find joy in each other's company, courage in each other's support, and room to grow as individuals and together. Friends and family, carry the spirit of this moment into the years ahead: celebrate with them, listen to them, and remind them of the love that surrounds them. [If the couple wants a kiss, invite it.] Please join me in celebrating [Name] and [Name]! [Pause for applause.]

Recessional / 1 min

Cue the exit song, let the couple clear the aisle, then release the wedding party. Tell guests where to go next and who can help with transport.

The timing check

$1 + 1.5 + 2 + 1 + 3 + 1.5 + 1 + 1 = 12$ minutes. Time the personal story, reading and vows separately. If a ritual or translation is added, extend the schedule instead of rushing the couple.

Be a calm, prepared voice

The friend officiant role starts with the couple's approval and a shared rehearsal plan.

Agree the role

Confirm whether you are leading a symbolic celebration or participating alongside another officiant. If a legal ceremony is intended, the couple must verify requirements and the officiant's authority with the relevant local authority.

Prepare the words

Ask how each name is pronounced, how the couple wants to be introduced, and which traditions or acknowledgements matter. Get approval for the complete script. Do not add surprise stories or jokes.

Rehearse the handoffs

Walk the processional, microphone handoffs, reading, vows, rings, kiss if wanted and recessional. Agree clear music cues and keep a printed backup of the final script.

Check the space

Ask the venue team where to stand, where cables run and how to reach the weather backup. Confirm water, shade or shelter, accessible seating and the person authorised to change the plan.

Lead gently

Speak slowly, leave room for emotion and pause if a guest or participant needs help. At the end, tell guests exactly where to go and who can assist them.

Your rehearsal card

Decision / cue	Named owner or confirmed detail
Final script approved by	_____
Music and microphone cues	_____
Rings / ritual materials	_____
Weather decision / deadline	_____
Guest directions / assistance	_____

Need help joining the pieces? Request a free 30-minute consultation or explore the \$300 Feasibility Plan at www.ceremonyverse.com. Email: hello@ceremonyverse.com